

Learn what documents you will need to get a Social Security Card | Social Security Administration

Replacement Card for a Noncitizen Adult

You can replace your Social Security card for free if it is lost or stolen. However, you may not need to get a replacement card, knowing your Social Security number is what's important. You are limited to three (3) replacement cards in a year and 10 during your lifetime. Legal name changes and other exceptions do not count toward these limits. Also, you may not be affected by these limits if you can prove you need the card to prevent a significant hardship.

In general, only noncitizens who have permission to work from the Department of Homeland Security (DHS) can apply for a Social Security number. If you do not have permission to work but need a Social Security number for other purposes, see "If you do not have permission to work" for further information.

Important

You must present original documents or copies certified by the agency that issued them. We cannot accept photocopies or notarized copies. All documents must be current (not expired). We cannot accept a receipt showing you applied for the document.

What original documents do I need?

Immigration status

To prove your U.S. immigration status, you must show us your current U.S. immigration document, such as:

- Form I-551 (Lawful Permanent Resident Card, Machine Readable Immigrant Visa);
- I-766 (Employment Authorization Document, EAD, work permit); or
- I-94 (Arrival/Departure Record) or admission stamp in the unexpired foreign passport.

If you are an F-1 or M-1 student, you also must show us your I-20 (Certificate of Eligibility for Nonimmigrant Student Status).

If you are a J-1 or J-2 exchange visitor, you must show us your DS-2019 (Certificate of Eligibility for Exchange Visitor Status).

Work eligibility

In general, only noncitizens who have permission to work from DHS can apply for a Social Security number. If you are a foreign worker, we only need to see an I-94 (Arrival/Departure Record) or admission stamp in the unexpired foreign passport showing a class of admission permitting work. Some foreign workers must show their I-766 (Employment Authorization Document, EAD, work permit) from DHS.

Student: If you are an F-1 student and eligible to work on campus, you must provide a letter from your designated school official that:

- Identifies you;
- Confirms your current school status; and
- Identifies your employer and the type of work you are, or will be, doing.

We also need to see evidence of that employment, such as a recent pay slip or a letter from your employer. Your supervisor must sign and date the letter. The letter must describe:

- Your job;
- Your employment start date;
- The number of hours you are, or will be, working; and
- Your supervisor's name and telephone number.

If you are an F-1 student authorized to work in curricular practical training (CPT), you must provide us your Form I-20 with the employment page completed and signed by your designated school official.

If you are an F-1 student and have a work permit (I-766) from DHS, you must present it.

If you are a J-1 student, student intern or international visitor, you must provide a letter from your sponsor. The letter should be on sponsor letterhead with an original signature that authorizes your employment.

If you do not have permission to work: Lawfully admitted noncitizens can get many benefits and services without a Social Security number. You do not need a number to conduct business with a bank, register for school, apply for educational tests, obtain private health insurance, apply for school lunch programs or apply for subsidized housing. You cannot get a Social Security number for the sole purpose of obtaining a driver's license.

Government benefits or services: If you do not have permission to work, you may apply for a Social Security number only if:

- A federal law requires you to provide your Social Security number to get a particular benefit or service; or
- A state or local law requires you to provide your Social Security number to get general assistance benefits for which you already have qualified.

If you need a number to meet these state or local requirements, you must bring us a letter from the government agency. It must be on letterhead stationery (no form letters or photocopies) and:

- Specifically identify you as the applicant;
- Cite the law requiring you to have a Social Security number;
- Indicate that you meet all the agency's requirements, except having the number; and
- Contain an agency contact name and telephone number.

Taxes: If you need a number for tax purposes and you are not authorized to work in the United States, you can apply for an Individual Taxpayer Identification Number from the Internal Revenue Service (IRS). Visit IRS in person or call the IRS toll-free number, 1-800-TAXFORM (1-800-829-3676), and request Form W-7 (Application for IRS Individual Taxpayer Identification Number).

If you are assigned a number for non-work purposes, you cannot use it to work. If you use it to work, we will inform DHS.

Identity

Social Security will ask to see a current DHS document. Acceptable documents include:

- I-551 Permanent Resident Card;
- I-94 Arrival/Departure Record with unexpired foreign passport or admission stamp in the unexpired foreign passport; or
- I-766 Employment Authorization Document, (EAD, work permit) from DHS.

Note

We may use one document for two purposes. For example, we may use a DHS work permit as proof of both immigration status and identity.